

The Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry regulates the export activities of the kangaroo meat industry by:

- registering processing facilities for export
- overseeing production to ensure food safety, and
- issuing export certification for kangaroo meat and meat products.

The department is also involved in developing and maintaining market access for kangaroo products worldwide. Exporters currently have market access to approximately 60 overseas markets, where they deliver high quality fresh meat cuts to restaurants and dinner tables across the globe.

Australia's commercial kangaroo industry, which began in 1959, is considered one of the world's best wild harvest operations. Kangaroo meat is sustainably and humanely sourced.

Sustainable and humane harvesting

Four species of kangaroo and 2 species of wallaby are permitted for commercial harvesting for meat export:

- red kangaroo (*Osphranter rufus*)
- eastern grey kangaroo (*Macropus giganteus*)
- western grey kangaroo (*Macropus fuliginosus*)
- common wallaroo, also known as the euro (*Osphranter robustus*)
- Tammar wallaby (*Macropus eugenii*)
- Bennetts wallaby (*Notamacropus rugosus*).

These species are widespread and abundant. None are endangered, threatened with extinction or listed in the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora (CITES) database.

All state-managed harvest of kangaroos and wallabies for export must have an approved management plan under the Environment Protection and Biodiversity Conservation Act 1999 (EPBC Act). These plans include conservative annual harvest quotas, based on scientifically robust population monitoring. The plans also implement zoning, to support even population control and prevent localised depletion. Harvest quotas are monitored and reviewed annually, and harvest quotas are reduced when population monitoring detects declines. [Approved state government wildlife trade management plans](#) and [wildlife trade operations](#) for commercial harvests of kangaroos are published on the Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water website.

There have been no adverse long-term impacts on kangaroo populations after more than 40 years of harvesting under commercial management plans, including during periods of severe droughts. Harvested numbers are linked to market demand and commercial production capacity. State governments that harvest kangaroos under commercial management plans publish annual reports that document harvest quotas and actual harvest numbers.

Kangaroos are free-ranging animals and are not confined, herded, transported, or treated in any other way that may cause stress prior to harvest. To ensure kangaroos are harvested humanely, all commercial operations must comply with the [National Code of Practice for the Humane Shooting of Kangaroos and Wallabies for Commercial Purposes](#) (the Code).

Why harvest

Kangaroo populations can grow rapidly when conditions are right. Managing kangaroo numbers contributes positively to the overall welfare of kangaroo populations. Management also protects Australia's ecosystems and biodiversity by reducing grazing pressure on native vegetation (Hills et al. 2020; Prowse et al. 2019).

Kangaroos are low emitters of methane gas by nature, making them a sustainable meat choice.

References

Hills, CH, Waudby, H, Finlayson, G, Parker, D, Cameron, M & Letnic, M 2020, [Grazing by over-abundant native herbivores jeopardizes conservation goals in semi-arid reserves](#) , vol. 24, DOI: 10.1016/j.gecco.2020.e01384, accessed 8 November 2022.

Prowse, TA, O'Connor, PJ, Collard, SJ & Rogers, DJ 2019, [Eating away at protected areas: Total grazing pressure is undermining public land conservation](#) , vol. 20, DOI: 10.1016/j.gecco.2019.e00754, accessed 8 November 2022.

Nutritious, sourced from healthy free-ranging animals

Recognised as a valuable source of protein for thousands of years, kangaroo meat has been consumed by First Nations people since they first arrived on this continent around 60,000 years ago.

Kangaroo meat is high in energy, protein, iron, zinc, omega 3 fatty acids and B vitamins. It also contains less than 2% fat, making it one of the best sources of lean animal protein.

Kangaroo meat can be used in the same way as traditional red meat. It is also suitable for use in further manufacturing, such as for meat patties, sausages and jerky.

As kangaroos are not farmed animals, they have not been treated with veterinary medicines or pesticides.

Studies of wild populations have found no long-term impacts resulting from more than 30 years of commercial harvesting. This is due to the use of strict and regulated quotas that are based on scientific survey methods.

State governments administer annual harvest quotas that set the maximum number of kangaroos to be removed from each zone in harvesting areas. Zoning encourages even population control and prevents local depletion.

State management plans are approved by the Australian Government Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry before being implemented. Populations are then closely monitored to ensure that any unexpected declines can be detected and harvest quotas adjusted accordingly.

With a focus on sustainability, harvest quotas have generally been set at around 15-20% of the estimated population species permitted for harvest. However, harvest is generally significantly less than the approved quota—at around 3% of the total kangaroo population—as harvesting is linked to market demand and commercial production capacity. For example, [in 2021](#), NSW used 31% of its annual quota, Queensland used 30%, and South Australia only used 22%. State annual reports record percentages of annual harvest quotas used each year.

Kangaroo meat is an environmentally friendly source of lean protein. Kangaroos are low emitters of methane gas by nature, making them a sustainable choice. Farming development across Australia has led to the introduction of water points and increased grazing area, creating favourable conditions for kangaroos. Like any animal, when the conditions are right, populations will boom. When there are large populations of kangaroos, they can cause significant damage to the environment. In managed populations, kangaroos cause less destruction to native vegetation, preserving habitat for smaller native species. Kangaroos are soft-footed, which means less damage to soil and vegetation, helping to maintain ground cover and biodiversity of plant species, when in effectively managed populations.

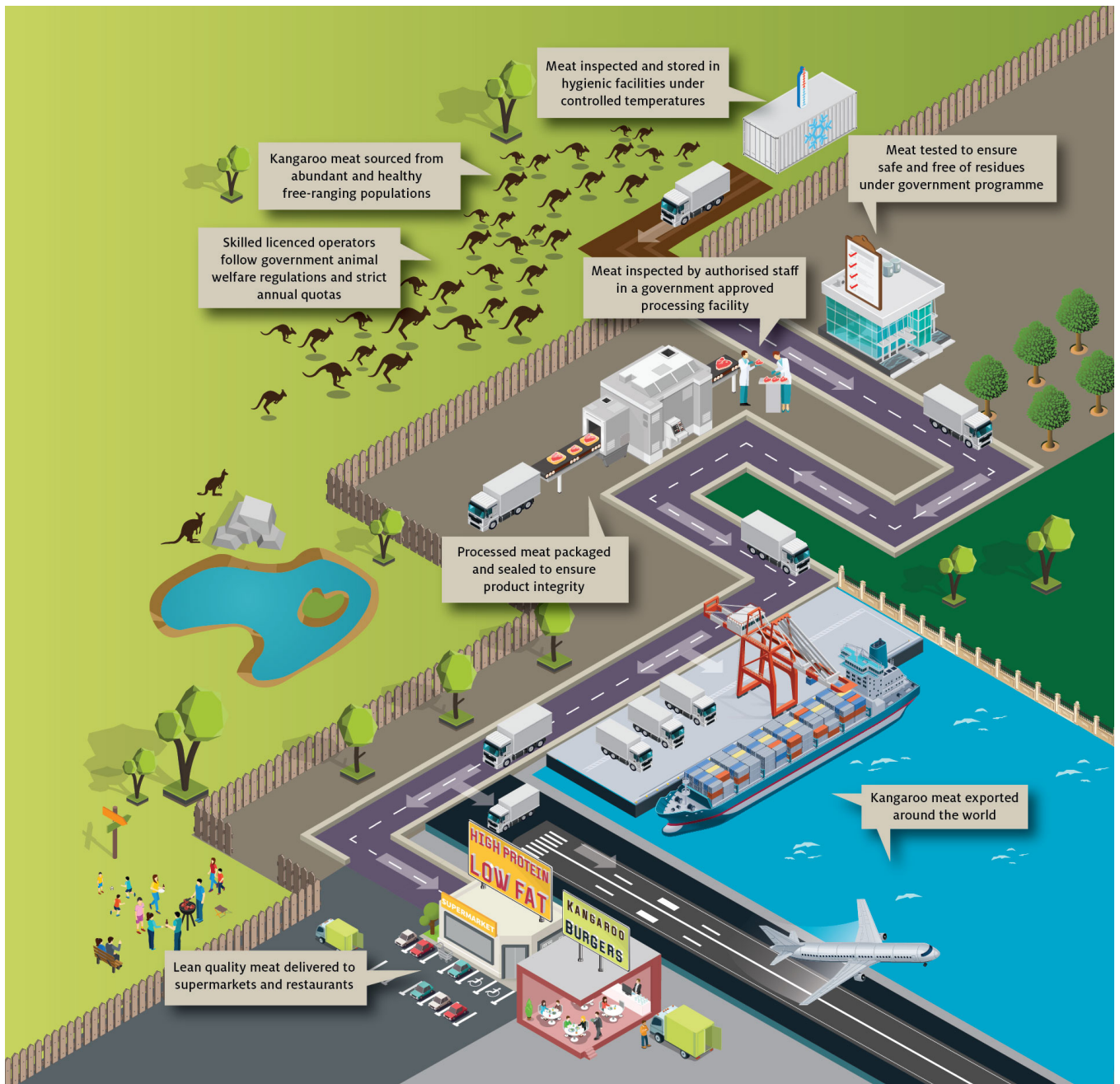
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Kangaroo meat is carefully managed, from skilled harvest operations to the consumers' plate.



- Kangaroo meat is sourced from abundant and healthy free-ranging populations. When sourcing kangaroo meat, skilled licenced operators follow government animal welfare regulations and strict quotas.
- Meat is inspected and stored in hygienic facilities under controlled temperatures. It is tested under a government programme to ensure that it is safe and free from residues.
- Meat is again inspected by authorised staff in government approved processing facilities.
- Once at the processors, high quality cuts are selected before being processed, packaged and sealed to ensure product integrity.
- High quality lean kangaroo meat is exported by sea and air around the world.
- Lean kangaroo meat is delivered to supermarkets and restaurants for people to enjoy.